

JD(S) chief H.D. Deve Gowda has said he is "too small a person to be approached and has not yet applied his mind". Others, mostly one-MP parties, would like to decide "after discussing it with their party". Translated, it means that they are waiting for the call and "nobody has approached us" obviously is the euphemism for "we are willing to negotiate". The scope: at last count, UPA had 260 committed supporters and as with any poll, the undecided, who account for 18 seats, hold the key.

It is both an opportunity for those footloose and a challenge for the Congress. By July 9, when Karat led the Left Front to meet the President, the Congress had a crack team led by veteran Pranab Mukherjee comprising Parliamentary Affairs Minister Vayalar Ravi, Party General Secretary Ahmad Patel, Agriculture Minister Sharad Pawar and Railways Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav doing the math. The specialists are on the job. Ghulam Nabi

Azad has been asked to use his equation with the Abdullahs to bring in the National Conference (NC) while Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi is wooing Mamata Banerjee from his hospital bed. The logic being sold to Banerjee is that she cannot be seen voting with the Left. Patel, having brokered the Samajwadi alliance, is masterminding the entire operation while Mukherjee is hoping and lobbying that the Left could walk out instead of voting along with BJP. And true to Congress-style durbar politics, each leader has assured party President Sonia Gandhi that this time around it will not be a repeat of 1999 when Arjun Singhji was deputed to bring in the requisite 272!

For many in the party, this is a do-or-die situation. For four years, the Government has been seen tottering at the brink of indecision. Yes, there has been the big-tag spend on pro-poor programmes but none have mattered in the 12 successive electoral defeats.

This is seen as their moment of decisive politics. The N-Deal is seen as the big idea that could just deliver on the plank of national interest. Sure it is difficult to articulate national interest in electoral language but it is esoteric and just as difficult to rubbish. Most importantly, for the Congress this is the coming together of an idea, the prime minister and the leadership. The party seems to have absorbed the fact that Sonia Gandhi has backed the prime minister despite objections within and in spite of the risks involved.

It is early days as yet but Ravi was optimistic: "UPA will have the numbers to survive and make the nuclear deal happen". The proactive strategy is to get JD(S), RLD and Trinamool to vote with them along with four Independent MPs. That would take the tally to 270. This would be backed by a defensive strategy to get parties like TRS and NC to abstain along with the two jailed SP MPs. That would bring down the target

BATTLE FOR SURVIVAL

Parties like JD(S), Trinamool Congress and RLD hold the key as the Congress tries to cobble together votes to save the government

543 Present strength of the Lok Sabha

272 Votes required for UPA's survival

18 UNDECIDED



2 IN JAIL

Graphics by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY